

'VISTARA ASPIRES TO BE RANKED AMONG THE WORLD'S BEST'

CEO Vinod Kannan reveals the airline's plans for a post-pandemic world, the relevance of a full-service carrier now, and how Vistara plans to expand operations

36 | BY **MANISH PANT**
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HE HAS BEEN amply exposed to both full-service and low-cost formats of the airline industry, has first-hand knowledge of all the business functions, and has served in important markets in Southeast Asia, Europe and the Middle-East. Meet Vinod Kannan, the young CEO of full-service carrier Vistara, a 51:49 joint venture between Tata Sons and Singapore Airlines. Elevated to the role in the New Year, Kannan, who is in his early forties and joined Singapore Airlines in 2001, throws light on his strategy for Vistara amid the recovery in passenger traffic in a post-Covid-19 world and the current geopolitical uncertainties. Edited excerpts:

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Where is the place for a full-service carrier in the Indian market? Not just in terms of positioning, but also in terms of the slots since it's just you and Air India today.

There used to be Jet Airways and Kingfisher Airlines in the past. But the fact remains [that] if you look at India as a market and the tremendous double-digit growth—putting aside the Covid-19 pandemic—



PANDEMIC EFFECT Vinod Kannan, CEO of Vistara, says the pandemic has delayed the full-service airline's expansion plans

that we've had over the last 10-15 years, [it] has led to an increase in disposable incomes. There are people who are getting a little bit richer, who have travelled the world and want to experience something along similar lines while flying within India. That proportion of people is willing to be value-conscious and pay a little bit more for a slightly more comfortable flight. That group of people

is expanding and will continue to expand. Our association both with the Tatas and Singapore Airlines puts us in a good position because people know there is a certain standing and there's a quality associated with that. But of course, the other side of the coin is that it also raises expectations. And maintaining them [expectations] and excelling every time is not easy.